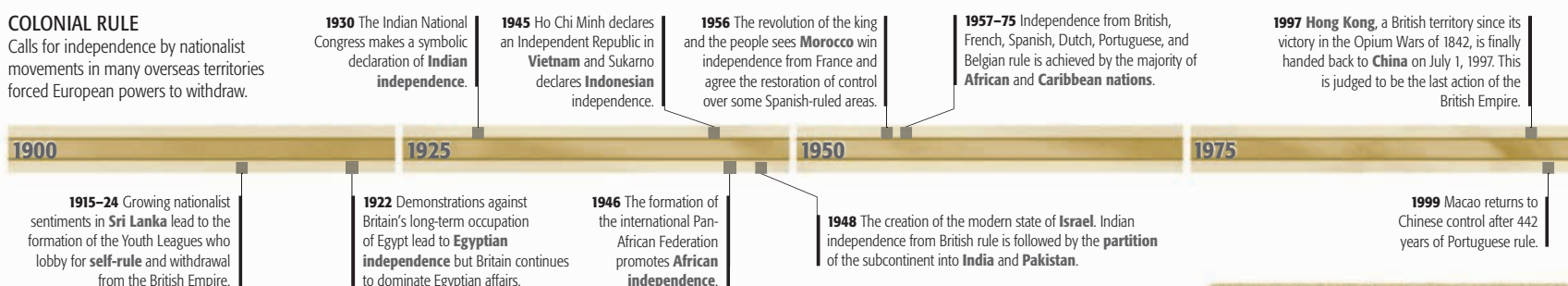


COLONIAL RULE

Calls for independence by nationalist movements in many overseas territories forced European powers to withdraw.



End of the Colonial Era

The decline of Europe's empires gathered momentum after World War II as domination of poorer nations by colonial powers came to be considered unacceptable. The transition from empire led to the creation of self-governing nation states in much of the world, but this created many new conflicts.

In 1945, the old justification for empire—that “inferior” races needed the guidance of “superior” Western civilization—came into question. In the aftermath of war there was a real desire to build a new and better world (see p.397). Many colonies had remained deeply impoverished and underdeveloped to suit the economic needs of empire. However, European powers were now forced to admit that this could no

longer be accepted and some countries reluctantly began to prepare for a withdrawal from imperial territories.

End of empire

Unfortunately, this new recognition of the rights of “Third World” countries to self-govern coincided with the advent of the Cold War (pp.406–07). The transition to independent status of some former colonies was complicated by the superpowers—the US and the Soviet Union—who competed for influence over the people's choice of government. In the colonies themselves there was conflict between different social, political, and ethnic factions over who should govern. In many cases, European powers caused resentment by trying to hold on to their interests in resources, such as oil and gemstones, even after independence was granted.

As a result, transitions to independence were often marked by civil wars and intervention from foreign powers.

Withdrawal from colonies

In Indonesia, resentment of their Dutch imperial masters was so intense that Japanese invaders were initially welcomed during World War II. The Dutch were unwilling to surrender their interests in Indonesian oil and rubber. They invaded in 1945 to re-establish control, but conceded Indonesian independence in 1949, although they continued to occupy Western New Guinea. A full Indonesian Republic was not created until 1960. During World War II the German-backed Vichy regime in French Indochina, which incorporated Vietnam, Laos, and Cambodia, also collaborated with Japan. In 1945 the

PRESIDENT OF EGYPT (1918–1970)

GAMAL ABDEL NASSER

From an early age, Nasser was interested in the fight for Egyptian independence. During World War II, he was involved in plans for a military coup to oust British forces from Egypt. These plans never reached fruition, but in 1952 Nasser spearheaded the Egyptian Revolution, becoming president (1956–70). Nasser's victory in the Suez Crisis of 1956 (see right) established him as a figurehead for Arab nationalism.



Vietnamese nationalist Ho Chi Minh took advantage of the Japanese surrender to declare an Independent Democratic Vietnamese Republic. French troops invaded the new republic and by 1946 had taken control of the south of the country, while Minh's army (Viet Minh) held the north. The French Indochina War lasted from 1946–54, when massive French losses at the Battle of Dien Bien Phu finally precipitated a settlement. The country was divided into North and South Vietnam. Tensions between the two nations later escalated into the Vietnam War (see pp.430–31).

In the British colony of Malaya, an initially peaceful transition to self-government developed into conflict in 1948. Hostility toward Britain's intention to maintain business interests in Malay rubber and tin combined with political and ethnic divisions in the population to create civil unrest. An armed insurrection by the communist minority resulted in the death of three European plantation managers in June



Ships scuttled in the Suez Canal

Ships sunk by Egyptian forces block the entrance to the Suez Canal. On the extreme right of the picture, a British naval salvage vessel attempts to clear the channel.

BEFORE

By the early 20th century the spread of nationalist ideas led to the growth of independence movements in the colonies.

COLONIES AND EMPIRES

Before World War II, European powers still **dominated much of the world**—Africa was largely divided between the British, French, Belgian, and Portuguese << 360–61; much of Asia and the Caribbean also remained under imperial rule. In the Middle East, mandates granted by the League of Nations gave Britain and France administrative powers over the region.

COLONIAL ECONOMIES

Colonial territories tended to be under-industrialized, and in many the standard of living was very low. They supplied raw materials to power European industry, but the **development of their own national economies** was not seen as a priority.

RISE OF NATIONALISM

Increasingly, **citizens demanded the right to self-govern**. The imperial powers began to make some concessions toward power-sharing but remained determined to hold on to economic control of the natural resources of their colonies.